TL

THE LEDGER

Artists sign contracts they cannot read.
The Ledger reads them first, in plain language, before anyone signs.

Theme 2 · Experienced Developers

Modernize What Matters

Terrance Franklin, T&F Investments and Holdings LLC · James Max Victor, Zealous Mirror Inc.
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THE PROBLEM

A contract, a deadline, and no lawyer.

An artist is handed a long document and asked to sign it this week. The barrier is not that every contract is predatory. It is that the terms which decide the next ten years are unreadable in the time available.

Ownership

Who owns the master recording, and for how long. Often in perpetuity, stated once, in a clause that does not look like the important one.

Revenue

What share reaches the artist after fees, splits and recoupment. The headline percentage is rarely the number that arrives.

Duration

Option triggers, delivery commitments and re-recording restrictions that outlive the deal itself.

No invented statistics appear in this deck. We do not have adoption figures or user counts, so none are shown.

WHAT IT DOES

Upload. Extract. Analyse. Explain.

1 · Upload

A PDF or text contract. Six refusal rules decide, before any analysis, whether the document can actually be read.

2 · Extract

Real text extraction from the uploaded file. If nothing extractable is found, the artist is told that and nothing else is shown.

3 · Analyse

Risk scoring, clause breakdown, a rights graph of who holds what, and a revenue waterfall from gross receipts to net payout.

4 · Explain

Plain language, with the questions worth asking an attorney named explicitly.

It is education, not legal advice, and the product says so to the artist. Knowing what a tool is not is part of building it.

WHAT EXISTED BEFORE BOB

The baseline, frozen and tagged.

Tag `pre-bob-baseline-2026-09-29` at commit `41339c6`. Everything claimed later is measured against this point.

WHAT THE README PROMISED	WHAT THE CODE DID
PDF contract upload	Partially false. PDFs were accepted by the file input, but their contents were never parsed. Canned sample text was sent to the AI instead.
Safe error handling	Provider errors reached the browser verbatim, including upstream detail that should never leave the server.
Tested	No test suites existed. Zero automated checks on the baseline commit.

This slide earns the right to claim an improvement. Without a frozen baseline, every later number is just an assertion.

HOW WE USED BOB

Audit, verify, plan, build. Each step left an artefact.

Audit

Bob read the repository read only and produced a Phase 1 assessment. No files written.

Verify

Every Bob finding checked by hand against the source before any of it was accepted.

Plan

Bob proposed the extraction approach. We amended it before building.

Build

Changes landed on branches with tests, then merged into one integration branch.

.bobignore

We bounded what Bob was allowed to read, and said in the file itself what that is not: it is a scope limit, not a security control.

A constraint Bob broke

An early run wrote a file despite a no write instruction. We caught it on review and discarded the work. We were checking, which is why we noticed.

WHERE BOB WAS WRONG

Three claims that did not survive checking.

WHAT BOB SAID	WHAT WE FOUND	OUTCOME
"gemini-3.6-flash is not a real model"	It is listed as a current model. Bob's suggested replacements are shut down or older.	Model name unchanged. Raised twice, rejected twice.
"JSON.parse is outside the try/catch"	It is inside.	No change made.
"Two lockfiles in the repo"	Only `bun.lock` is tracked. The other came from a local install.	No change made.

Two further claims were marked **still unverified** rather than accepted or dismissed: the Stripe stub details, and a waterfall math divergence between client and server. An unknown recorded as unknown is worth more than a confident guess.

The criterion asks whether Bob was core to the workflow, not whether Bob was right. Corrections in a written log are the evidence that its output was read rather than pasted.

CHANGE ONE

Real extraction, and an honest refusal.

The canned text is gone. Six refusals, each with its own message, decided before anything is sent to the AI.

CONDITION	WHAT THE ARTIST IS TOLD
Unsupported type	DOCX and DOC are named as not supported yet, rather than guessed at.
Over 10 MB	The size limit, stated.
Missing `%PDF-` header	The file does not appear to be a valid PDF.
No extractable text	This may be a scanned or image only PDF.
Password protected	An unlocked copy is requested.
Corrupt or unreadable	It could not be read.

A server side cap on contract text length was our amendment, not Bob's plan. The rules live in one module the component calls, so each is testable without a browser.

CHANGE TWO

A quota is not a crash.

Guarded parsing

A malformed or empty model response is caught and reported as unreadable, instead of throwing where the caller cannot see it.

Errors stay server side

Provider error detail no longer reaches the browser. The artist gets a message, not a stack trace.

503 when unconfigured

If the AI is not configured, the server says so with a 503 and a named code, rather than returning a 500 that reads like a bug.

Degrade, do not discard

A reply missing optional detail is shown with what it does contain. Dropping a whole analysis over one absent field serves nobody.

Degrade rather than discard is a product decision, and worth naming as one. The free tier allows 20 analyses a day, and the app used to report that limit as a crash.

INDEPENDENT VERIFICATION

Four defects neither Bob nor the author caught.

DEFECT	WHY IT MATTERED
A refused upload still rendered a results panel, populated with a sample contract's analysis	An artist uploading a scanned deal was told "no extractable text found" and shown a full risk score for a document they had never seen.
The word `undefined` printed into an artist's exported PDF	An optional field was interpolated without a guard, into the document the artist keeps.
Extracted rules were copied, not moved	The inline originals were still running, so the tests written for them guarded nothing. Found while rehearsing the demo.
CI was not running the newly arrived suites	Checks existed and passed locally while CI never executed them.

Bob did not find these. Review did. We are not claiming otherwise.

THE EVIDENCE

Every number here was produced by running it.

182	0	10	3	4
automated checks across 8 suites	checks on the frozen baseline	modernization log entries	Bob claims corrected	defects found in review

SUITE	CHECKS	WHAT IT COVERS
`test:upload`	35	the six refusal rules and the accept path
`test:aierror`	45	upstream failures mapped to honest status codes
`test:aiauth`	28	credential resolution, including Application Default Credentials
`test:analysis`	22	the analysis response contract
`test` · `test:regression` · `test:share` · `test:ci`	21 · 15 · 10 · 6	validator, upload regressions, share text, and a check that CI runs the others

Measured on the integration branch on 18 October 2026, every suite exiting zero. Each gate was shown failing on a deliberately broken build before it was trusted.

LEARNINGS AND NEXT STEPS

The dangerous failure is a plausible answer, not a crash.

What we learned

- A crash is visible. A confident analysis of the wrong contract is not.
- Bob opened the work. People closed it.
- Freeze the baseline first, or every later claim is unfalsifiable.

What is next

- Calibrate the scan threshold against real documents rather than a fixed length.
- Report real upload progress instead of fixed waypoints.
- Add DOCX, and keep refusing legacy .doc rather than guessing at it.

One limit stated plainly: the deployed demo runs without AI credentials, so contract analysis there returns a 503 saying exactly that. The live extraction in the demo video was filmed against a development build running on Vertex.

An artist should know what they are signing.

LIVE DEMO	http://65.108.146.243/
DEMO VIDEO	https://youtu.be/BXjVQ60cC4I
CODE	github.com/youngslim4985-sketch/The-Ledgerv2
SUBMISSION	github.com/youngslim4985-sketch/The-Ledger-IBM-Bob

THE LEDGER · Built with IBM Bob · 182 automated checks across 8 suites

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